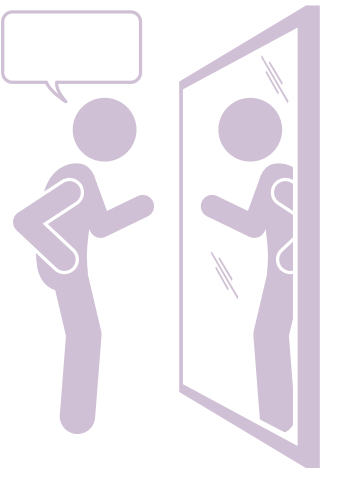
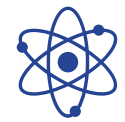




Talking to Yourself About Physical Activity

We all talk to ourselves. The way we talk to ourselves can be classified as positive or negative, motivating or de-motivating. Having an **awareness** of how we talk to ourselves about physical activity can help us leverage our self talk towards motivating us.



Studies show that adopting positive self-talk strategies can help improve physical activity performance, and re-framing can help individuals reduce biased exercise thoughts when making behaviour change efforts.

There are three skills related to talking to yourself: **Positive Self-Talk**, **Self-Praise**, and **Positive Re-framing**.

1) Positive Self-Talk

Self-Talk is a form of verbal persuasion that can be used to argue against self-doubt and persuade yourself of your capability to perform a behaviour.

How does it work?

There are two types of self-talk:

Motivational: Self-talk that improves confidence, mood, and effort. For example, *"I can do this, "I feel confident," "let's go."*

Instructional: Self-talk that focuses on processes and procedures of the activity, aimed at increasing technical ability. For example, *"raise your elbow", "feel the stretch," "keep back straight."*

Self-Talk, no matter the type, works best when it is:

- **Positive**, as opposed to negative
- **Overt**, even if you are just saying it out loud to yourself
- **Freely chosen** by you
- **Motivating** to you

2) Self Praise

Self Praise is a form of self-talk that is reserved for when you have **made progress or want to reward effort** in performing the behaviour. For example, saying *"I'm proud of myself for reaching my goal this week"* after finishing your final walk of the week, or *"I deserve this feeling of relief"* after completing an extra rep during a strength workout.

CASE STUDY

Christine has young-onset rheumatoid arthritis and she keeps up a weekly exercise routine that consists of strength training and walking. Exercising makes Christine feel accomplished, and she enjoys that feeling. However, some weeks she also lacks motivation to exercise, especially when she is in pain or recovering from a flare. Christine decides to adopt some positive self-talk and self praise statements to help her.

Positive Self-Talk

To get motivated to exercise before starting, Christine uses **motivational self-talk**:

I'll feel better after I walk.

Consistency is important to me.

Christine says these thoughts out loud. She reflects that when she remembers to tell herself these things, she is more motivated to complete her exercise.

Self Praise

Christine wants to reward her efforts during strength training, specifically when doing sit-ups, since these are especially difficult for her. She decides to reserve a self-praise statement for when she finishes this exercise:

I'm proud of myself for pushing through, even when it felt impossible.

3) Positive Re-framing*

As humans, we can sometimes be our harshest critic and we can all experience negative self-talk. **Positive re-framing** is a skill used to **re-frame negative self-talk** to take a more positive view of your situation.

How does it work?

It is important to recognize that negative self-talk can arise from **cognitive errors**:

Cognitive Error	Definition	Example
All or nothing thinking	When you can only see a situation in two extremes categories.	"I only have time for a 30 minute workout instead of my usual 1 hour workout, so there's no point in doing it."
Mental filter	When you only pay attention to one aspect of the situation.	"Thinking about physical activity, I can only think about how hard it will be."
Catastrophizing	Predicting future negative outcomes without considering more likely positive outcomes.	"I haven't been successful doing physical activity in the past, so why both trying when I'm probably going to fail?"
Emotional Reasoning	Inferring truth based on belief while ignoring evidence to the contrary.	"I'm feeling stressed this week so I'm not going to do physical activity."

Luckily, we can recognize our biased thoughts and re-frame them:

Step 1

Identify the biased thought and the cognitive error this may be

Step 2

Evaluate the evidence for and against the thought

Step 3

Re-frame the thought

E.g.

"I completely failed my exercise goals because I did not exercise today."

- This is an example of **all or nothing thinking** because I'm thinking in black and white terms, not viewing my exercise journey as a continuum.

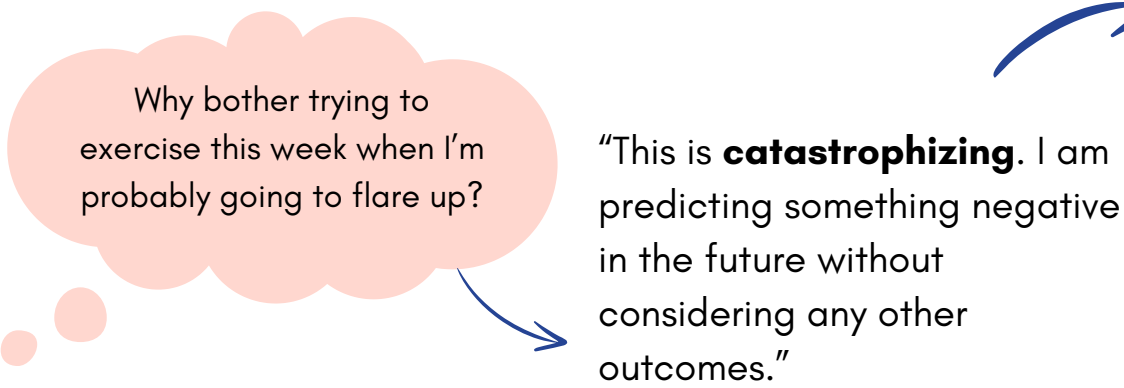
I am misinterpreting missing one day of exercise as a complete failure. I am feeling disappointed in myself for missing today, but that does not mean I am completely failing my exercise as a whole.

"I missed my exercise today, but one day out of the whole week, or even the whole year, is not too bad".

CASE STUDY

Christine has young-onset rheumatoid arthritis. When she tried to do exercise last week, she had a flare up with her condition at the same time. As a result, Christine thinks to herself, **"why both trying to do exercise this week when I'm probably going to flare up again?"** Christine recognizes that when she encounters this thought, her immediate response is to avoid completing her weekly exercise. She attempts to use positive re-framing to see if she can re-frame this thought.

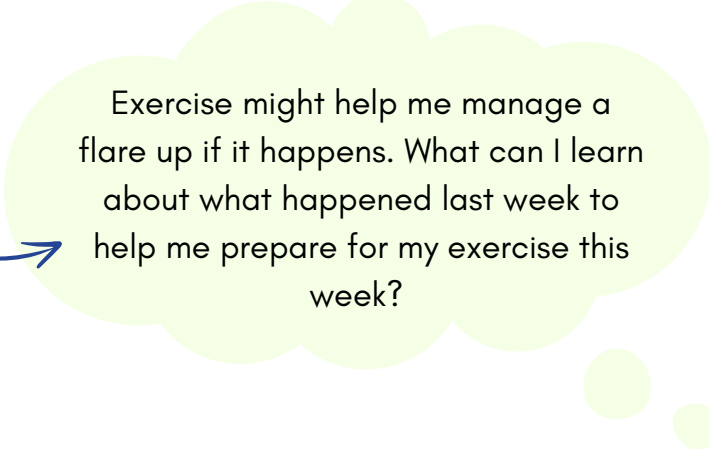
Step 1: Identify thought and cognitive error



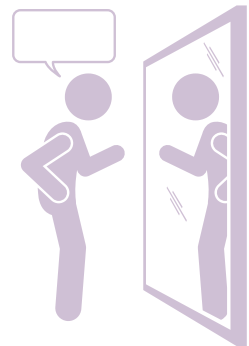
Step 2: Evaluate

"In the past, exercise has sometimes helped me manage pain during flare ups. Also, my flares are not always related to or dependent on my exercise. In the past I've been good at listening to my body during flares and breaking up my exercise into shorter bouts.

Step 3: Re-frame



*Materials adopted from Locke et al. (2019). "I'm just too busy to exercise": Reframing the negative thoughts associated with exercise-related cognitive errors. Psychology of Sport and Exercise 43: 279-287



Your Turn

Part 1: Recognizing Positive Self-Talk

1) What are some positive things you tell yourself when you are doing physical activity? If you can't think of any right now, skip to step 2) to gain a better idea of what type of self talk is most helpful for you. After completing step 2) return to the positive self-talk statements box to write your self talk statement.

Positive Self-Talk Statement(s):

Remember, self-talk that is freely chosen by you and said out loud (even if it's just to yourself) can make it more impactful.

2) What type of self-talk did you come up with / What type of self talk do you want to use?

☐ Motivational

☐ Instructional

Why this type?

3) Reflect on your self-talk.

When do I use this self-talk?

How often do I need to use this self-talk?

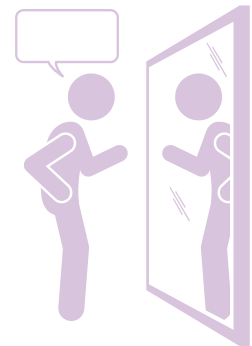
4) Think of a self praise statement that you use or would like to use when doing physical activity. What do you tell yourself when you've accomplished something?

Self Praise Statement:

5) Reflect on your self-praise statement:

Why did I choose this statement?

When will I use this self-praise statement?



Your Turn

Part 2: Working through Negative Self Talk*

1) What thought do you struggle with related to being physically active?

Negative/Biased Thought

What happens when you think this? Do you do or don't do physical activity? How do you feel?

2) Is there a cognitive error that your statement lines up with?

- ☐ **All or nothing thinking:** can only see the situation in two extremes
- ☐ **Mental filter:** only paying attention to one aspect of the situation
- ☐ **Catastrophizing:** predicting future negative outcomes without considering the more likely positive outcomes
- ☐ **Emotional reasoning:** inferring truth based on belief while ignoring evidence to the contrary

3) Evaluate the evidence for and against this statement. Consider: Am I exaggerating? Am I seeing both sides? Am I being realistic?

For

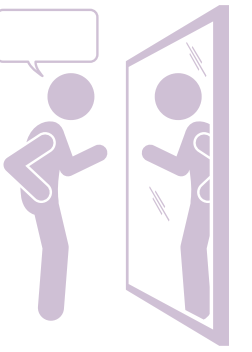
Against

4) Now that you have weighed the evidence for and against, come up with a new re-framed thought that aligns more with the evidence, and write the new balanced thought below.

New Balanced Thought



*Materials adopted from Locke et al. (2019). "I'm just too busy to exercise": Reframing the negative thoughts associated with exercise-related cognitive errors. Psychology of Sport and Exercise 43: 279-287



Reflection – *Talking To Yourself About Physical Activity*

Reflect on your experience using and practicing self talk, self praise, and/or positive re-framing this week. Use this space to write your overall impressions of using this skill. Respond to the reflection questions below:

- How is your positive self talk/self praise impacting your physical activity engagement?
- What are you finding useful about positive re-framing?